

Forwarding the Email Archive

Stewarding Donna J. Haraway’s Digital Correspondence at UC Santa Cruz

Who is Donna Haraway?

- Distinguished Professor Emerita at UC Santa Cruz (1980–present) in History of Consciousness & Feminist Studies
- Writer and interdisciplinary scholar whose work bridges biology, philosophy, and critical studies
- Widely known for her writings such as “A Cyborg Manifesto” (1985) & *Staying with the Trouble* (2016)

Pope Francis cited Haraway’s concept of interspecies “**contact zones**” in his 2023 climate change apostolic exhortation

In 2024, Haraway transferred her email correspondence (including over 85,000 messages dating back to 1998) to UCSC’s archives to be made available for research alongside the rest of her papers.

Our email processing workflow included:

1. Prepare

We visited Haraway’s home to discuss the transfer of her files to the library. She placed no access restrictions on her collection.

Haraway organizes her UCSC email in a “Saved Mail” folder in **Apple Mail**, with nested subfolders arranged by topic (e.g. Students, Conferences, Dogs, etc.). We decided we wouldn’t transfer/preserve emails that Haraway hadn’t already made the decision to “save.”

2. Transfer

We exported Haraway’s “Saved Mail” mailbox from her Apple Mail client, retaining her original subfolder structure and naming.

Apple Mail has a 2.15GB limit when exporting mailboxes from the application, and does not export nested subfolders of mailboxes.

To remedy this, we transferred files directly from her Mac directory: Users/[user]/Library/Mail, and took screenshots documenting the file structure.



Haraway’s email directory

3. Convert & Import

The Apple Mail files from Haraway’s directory were not .mbox, but instead proprietary .emlx files. We converted these using the **emailchemy** tool. We had previously used **ePADD** to process a different email collection, so we began with the same workflow, importing the 2,012 .mbox files (containing over 85,000 messages) to ePADD.

Our import attempts to ePADD, over the course of weeks, consistently failed. We were only able to import a few of the .mbox files which corresponded to topical subfolders.

4. Content Review

For the small number of .mbox files that *did* import, we began using **ePADD** lexicon libraries to identify sensitive content. The “Personal” .mbox did not import to ePADD and seemed to contain a lot of PII, so we decided to remove this entire subfolder from access.

Using **Mailbag**, we created a “bag” of individual email message PDFs, attachment files, and a .csv file manifest from each .mbox file. We then used **TreeSize Pro** to identify and remove files that contained PII.

Another helpful tool for content review was **DArcMail**, which created a searchable database from the .mbox files. This could also be a good tool for researcher access.



5. Preservation & Access

Along with other born digital files in the collection, we are preserving the PDFs of each email, attachment, and .csv manifest created by Mailbag in our institutional repository. These are now accessible for **in-person review only in the reading room**. The online collection guide includes a listing of the topical subfolders Haraway used to organize her mail.

We are retaining all original .emlx files (and converted .mbox) for future processing, as we anticipate more accruals for this collection... as well as technological advances in email processing!

Let’s discuss!

- What’s the right balance between accessibility and **privacy** when presenting email collections for research?
- What are the **risks** of providing fully open online access to digital files?
- Are there **ethical responsibilities** (beyond legal requirements) of archivists and institutions to protect third party **PII** in born digital archives?
- When processing very large email collections, should archivists consider **AI**-assisted content review? What privacy concerns arise?

Thinking like Haraway...

How can we “**stay with the trouble**” of our messy present when navigating the preservation and stewardship of digital files for the future?



Key Takeaways & Lessons Learned

- **Start early!** Trial and error is necessary; don’t expect a single tool to be able to process a whole email collection seamlessly
- Working directly with a donor to **curate emails before transfer** makes for more efficient processing
- .mbox files can be very unwieldy! Expect and embrace **troubleshooting** across file types
- Processing email requires **collaboration and dialogue** between software developers, institutions, donors, archivists and researchers

For more information, view the description of the email portion of the Donna Haraway Papers on the collection guide, included on the list of resources at this QR code:



The UC Santa Cruz Library’s Center for Archival Research and Training (CART) cultivates impactful learning experiences to develop students' archival research skills, support their career success, and increase access to unique library resources for all.

For more information, visit cart.ucsc.edu



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